Forests under Pressure: Evaluating the Sustainability of Community Forests in Kathmandu, Nepal

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Community Forests near Kathmandu (credit: ForestAction Nepal)

Project Description

Forests provide a lot of benefits: they support local biodiversity, generate ecosystem services, and sequester carbon. Yet deforestation and land degradation persist, especially in developing contexts where household livelihoods are closely tied to forest resources. One policy solution that has proven effective at conserving forests is 'Community Forests' – forests that local communities, rather than private entities or the government, manage.

Nepal's Community Forests are widely regarded as a successful model of community-based forest management, helping nearly double the country's forest cover since the 1980s. However, rapid urbanization and demographic transitions have drastically reduced household dependency on these forests, with many Community Forests now losing their value. This raises pressing questions about the role of Community Forests, which have long sustained the delicate relationship between people and forests, in Nepal's next decade of economic growth.

This project examines how local communities manage their Community Forests, with a focus on why households continue or cease to participate. The project will also identify the incentives surrounding Community Forests, along with their key benefits and costs to both people and the environment, with the goal of developing recommendations to strengthen Community Forest initiatives.

Student Research Assistants

I am looking for two research assistants for this project. You would work with me on research design, constructing household surveys, planning field observations, and using satellite data to track changes in the surrounding landscapes. You would also travel with me to Kathmandu for two weeks of fieldwork to gather data yourself, with travel costs covered.

The project is expected to produce a peer-reviewed paper, a policy report, and a set of StoryMaps, and you would be part of all three. You would also have the chance to add your own questions to the survey, so you can study a topic that interests you using the data we collect.

What this involves:

- Enrolling in ENVS 385 (*Research in Environmental Science*) in Spring 2027 under this project
- Participating in summer research for 6-8 weeks (contingent on a successful application as a Sustainability Scholar or Summer Science Scholar)
- Traveling to Kathmandu, Nepal for two weeks (late June to mid-July) for fieldwork

You do not need prior research experience or any background in Nepal. I am looking for students who are genuinely curious about how communities manage their local environmental resources, eager to learn new methods, and ready to commit the time and effort that research and fieldwork abroad require.

Interested in Participating?

If you are interested in the project, please send me an email (shakya1@kenyon.edu) and meet with me during office hours (Office Hour link) to discuss the project. I hope to finalize the research assistants before Thanksgiving Break.